

Encoded Archival Standards

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What are archival standards?

Archival standards are well-established best practices and guidelines for archival material. They help ensure that archival records can be described, linked, stored, with relations between context, people, organizations, and more, and all with long-term preservation in mind. Standards can establish authenticity, usability, interoperability, consistency, scalability, discovery and more! They come in various forms, and bring rigour, ease and professionalism to our job as archivists.

“Archives record decisions, actions and memories.”

(<https://www.ica.org/resource/universal-declaration-on-archives-uda/>)



There's a standard for that!

Who: Describing the creator (corporate bodies, persons, families)

<https://eac.staatsbibliothek-berlin.de/>, EAC-CPF (Encoded Archival Context - Corporate Bodies, Persons and Families)

What: Describing the records

<https://loc.gov/ead/>, EAD (Encoded Archival Description)

Why: Describing the function and/or activities that results in a record

<https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-TagLibraries/>, EAC-F (Encoded Archival Context - Functions)

Together, these are called Encoded Archival Standards (EAS)



Encoded Archival Standards

EAC-CPF (Encoded Archival Context - Corporate Bodies, Persons and Families)

EAD (Encoded Archival Description)

EAC-F (Encoded Archival Context - Functions)

These are maintained by the Technical Subcommittee on Encoded Archival Standards (TS-EAS) of the SAA Standards Committee



How are standards maintained?

- All archival standards are encoded in XML
 - Platform independent
 - Data-focused
 - Unicode compliant
 - Supports validation
 - Widely supported
- Encoding standards (EAD, EAC-F and EAC-CPF) are designed to be used
- The standards aim to meet community needs
- Standards include Tag Libraries *and* XML schemas
- Standards are actively maintained

```
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?>
<ead
  xmlns="https://standards.openpreservation.org/ead/v4"
  xmlns:xsi="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema-instance"
  xsi:schemaLocation="https://standards.openpreservation.org/ead/v4
  ead.xsd">
  <control>
    <!-- control subelements -->
  </control>
  <archDesc>
    <!-- archDesc subelements-->
  </archdesc>
</ead>
```



Why should I care?



Interoperability: Systems can exchange and use each other's data without custom translation for every pair of systems.



Consistency and Rigor: The same type of information can be recorded in the same way, making records comparable and aggregable. A date is a date, a name is a name, in a predictable place and format.



Longevity and Scalability: Information remains usable as systems change. Imagine if we had to write custom scripts for every piece of information each time we migrated to a new system.



Discovery: Consistent and connected description means that researchers can find materials across institutions and uncover relationships between content.



Professionalism and Compliance: Standards codify a community's consensus about what good archival description should be. They may also fulfill larger compliance needs. And sometimes the conversations to create those standards is as important as the standard itself.



Where can I find more about using standards?

Best Practice Guide (<https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-Best-Practices/>)



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[EAS Schemas](#) ▾
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Search Encoded Archival Standards Best Practices Guide

EAS BPG on GitHub

Encoded Archival Standards: Best Practices Guide

The Encoded Archival Standards: Best Practices Guide is a collaborative resource built to complement the EAS Tag Libraries for Encoded Archival Description (EAD), Encoded Archival Context - Corporate Bodies, Persons and Families (EAC-CPF) and Encoded Archival Context - Functions (EAC-F) - the XML-based standards for describing archival materials, their creators, and associated functions.

While the Tag Libraries define each element and attribute individually, the Best Practices Guide provides in-depth explanations of elements and attributes being used together to fulfill a variety of use cases. These are accompanied by encoded examples, to clarify the usage in practice.

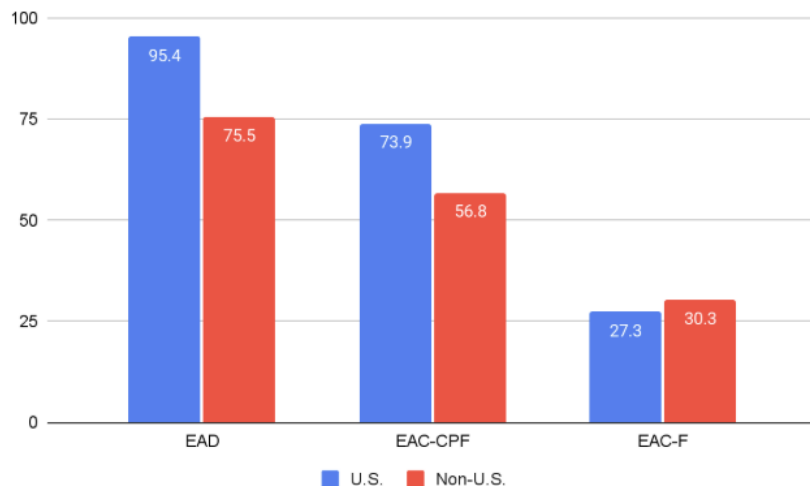
We are undergoing a major reorganization of the site during the approval process of the EAS schemas. In the meantime, archived pages for current best practices and recommendations remain in GitHub: <https://github.com/SAA-SDT/EAS-Best-Practices/tree/main/previous-versions/2025>



Do archivists know about these standards?

Yes!

Results from a 2026 global survey done by TS-EAS team on archival standards



What should I remember?

- There is a new version of the archival description standard. EAD 4 is open for implementation and feedback. <https://loc.gov/ead/>
- There's a new version for a standard for describing corporate bodies, persons, and families. EAC-CPF 3 is open for implementation and feedback. <https://eac.staatsbibliothek-berlin.de/>
- There's a new standard for describing functions that generate archival records. EAC-F 1 is open for implementation and feedback. <https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-TagLibraries/>
- This whole suite of standards for archivists, developers, and institutions is available to take advantage of. (<https://saa-sdt.github.io/EAS-Best-Practices/>)
- TS-EAS seeks feedback and support from the community. Get in touch! (ts-eas@archivists.org)



On behalf of TS-EAS Outreach Subteam

Thanks!

<https://www2.archivists.org/groups/technical-subcommittee-on-encoded-archival-standards-ts-eas>

